Pretty Fire

By Charlayne Woodward

CHARLAYNE: One day, when Allie and I were watching old black and white movies, Mommy walked into the living room and turned off the TV. She said,

MOM: Ladies, tell me, what would you like to be when you grow up?

CHARLAYNE: *(raising her hand)* Me first, Mommy, me first. I want to be . . . Shirley Temple. Yes, Mommy . . . I need to be Shirley Temple! Oh, Mommy, I want to live in a big white marble house with a huge spiral staircase that goes all the way up to heaven! And I will stand at the top of this staircase, right next to my happy negro butler! All dressed up in tux and tails and clean white gloves! And together we will come tap-dancing down the staircase . . . *(singing and tap-dancing)* Shabalabala! Shabalabala!

I wish to live in a land of cotton,

Old times there are never forgotten,

Look away, look away, look away Dixieland.

(finishes with a flourish and freezes in a minstrel pose)

Then Allie broke in

ALLIE: *(raising her hand)* Mommy, I want to be the happy negro maid, Mommy! Oh, Mommy! I want to be in charge of everything! Especially the big, wonderful kitchen, Mommy, and I will thaw out all the turkeys and all the hams, and I will bake them up and serve them out on the veranda to . . . *(serving an audience member)* the Colonel . . . and . . . *(serving Charlayne)* to my sister . . . Shirley Temple!

CHARLAYNE: *(singing and tap dancing)*

In Dixie land I'll take my stand

To live and die in Dixie . . .

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INTRODUCTION

It was a carefree world of children, imagining a future with endless possibilities . . . but Charlayne and her sister must learn why they're different from the white, pop-cultural icons like Shirley Temple and Aunt Jemima. Let me show you all the glorious paradoxes of childhood summers with grandparents in the Jim Crow South. Nostalgic memories of an all-black neighborhood full of sensual delights -- from squishy red Georgia clay to the cries of seafood peddlers . . . all is perfect through childhood eyes until we are forced to see the pain, hostility and the "pretty fire" of adversity lying just beneath the surface.

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CHARLAYNE: We loved "Dixie" . . . because "Dixie" meant the South. And the South meant our grandparents -- Grace Harris and Joe Harris. They lived in Dixie. As a matter of fact, in my neighborhood, everybody's grandparents lived in Dixie! When summertime came, nobody cared about which camp you were going to. Day camp . . . Overnight camp . . . please! The subject never even came up. As far as we were concerned, we were all going down to Dixie, where our grandparents spoiled us silly! As far as we were concerned, Dixie meant *Freedom*!

Daddy would drive that black Ford over those red clay road and pull up right in front of Grandmama's yard. Grandmama and Granddaddy would be up on the front porch, waving and throwing kisses. Allie and I'd rip ourselves out of the car and they would come down those stairs and smother us with hugs and kisses and I just knew . . . this was gonna be a summer of love!

My parents only stayed in Dixie for one week because there was this man in Dixie that my mother didn't like.

MOM: *(troubled, angry)* I tell you, Woody. I can't take this. I'm not used to this anymore. I tell you. I just can't stand Jim Crow!

CHARLAYNE: So after a week Daddy drove Mommy back to Albany. Then we had our grandparents all to ourselves, for the whole summer. I tell you, everything was ***different*** in Dixie! People had different jobs in Dixie! Wonderful jobs. Jobs like . . . picking beans and

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picking corn and picking cotton. Yes! And if you didn't want to pick your own food, the food came to you. There was this man that drove a big green truck.

MAN: *(driving, singing out)* Okra! Pecans! Watermelon! Okra! Pecan! Watermelon!

CHARLAYNE: Then, there was this wee, little man who wore a big straw hat that fell over his eyes. He came pushing a heavy cart.

MAN 2: *(pushing cart along)* Crabs, lobster, shimps! I got your shimps here! Crabs, lobster, shimps! I got your shimps here!

CHARLAYNE: All of a sudden, in the middle of a bright, sunny day, the whole sky would just open up and buckets and buckets of rain would pour down on us . . . while the sun was still shining. My grandmother would let us play in this rain . . . barefoot! And the red clay road in front of Grandmamma's house turned into red clay mud. Do you know how it feels like to have some red clay mud squishing in between your toes? Heaven!

I tell you, my grandmother was our hero! She was afraid of nothing! She would sit us on the front porch and teach us "life lessons."

GRANDMOTHER: *(Grace Harris, a tall, dignified woman with a strong voice, paces back and forth)* Never let anybody have the last word if you know you right! Okay, repeat after me. *(Grandmother's voice turns into Charlayne's voice at the /)* Never let anybody have the last word / if you are right.

CHARLAYNE: I tell you, my grandmother was our hero. She was afraid of nothing!

One evening just before dark, we were all outside playing in the road. The next thing we knew, parents and grandparents were grabbing children left and right, and whisking them off into their houses.

CHILD 1: What's the matter?

CHILD 2: What did we do?!

CHILD 3: I'm sorry.

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CHARLAYNE: Allie and I din't know what to do, so we just went and stood up under that pecan tree across the road from Grandmamma's house. Soon, Grandmamma came out on her porch looking for us. *(waving and calling out)* Over here, Grandmamma! We're over here!

Grandmamma ran down those steps, raced across that road, grabbed us both by the arms, pulled us into the house, and threw us up against the wall, under the windowsill. *(to Grandmother)* What's the matter, Grandmamma? What did we do?

GRANDMOTHER: Sssssh! Pray!

CHARLAYNE: But what are we praying for?

GRANDMOTHER: Ssssh! I said pray now!

CHARLAYNE: Granddaddy was seated right in front of us, in his rocking chair, facing the window. He had his glasses on, his Bible open on his lap, and ***he*** was praying.

GRANDFATHER: The Lord is my Shepard, I shall not want. He maketh me to lie down in green pastures; he leadeth me beside the still waters. He restoreth my soul . . . Yea, though I walk through the valley of the shadow of death, I will fear no evil. . .

CHARLAYNE: Grandmamma was sitting just in back of Granddaddy, against the opposite wall, but on the floor, just like us, facing us. We all just sat there as it got darker and darker. Soon, night replaced the day.

We just sat there until it was pitch black! And then I heard it: WHOOOOOOOOOOSH! *(excited)* Then we saw them flickering, flickering, in Granddaddy's glasses. Allie and I ***had*** to peek out that window. *(turns around, kneeling)* Only our eyes, only our eyes . . . above that windowsill! And there it was! Not two, like in Granddaddy's glasses, but one great big Jesus Christ cross! Flaming! Burning in the black night! *(arms outstretched; awestruck she speaks to the cross)* Beautiful . . . . ! Pretty fire . . .! Pretty fire . . . ! *(applauds softly)*

Suddenly, my grandmother came from nowhere. She yanked us around and shoved us back up against that wall. She looked right into our faces and said . . .

GRANDMOTHER: That is not ***pretty***! That is ***ugly***! That is the ***ugliest*** thing you will ever see! *(pause)*

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CHARLAYNE: I looked into my grandmother's face . . . filled with fire . . . and for the first time in my life, I saw . . . that Grandmamma was afraid *(pause)* She sat there with us all through the night as we watched that cross burn. *(long pause)* But everything was different this morning. All through breakfast, nobody spoke. Not one word.

When breakfast was over, Allie and I went out on the front porch and we looked up and down that road . . . Not a soul was out. *(pause)* We walked down that red clay road. Down to the bottom, down past Miss. Minnie's, to the ditch. *(notices the charred cross)*

And there it was. It was . . . big. Oh, it was much bigger than it looked from Grandmamma's window. And it was . . . black . . . with charcoals stuck to it all the way to the top. And . . . it had a horrible smell . . . Grandmamma was right . . . It was ugly. *(sings in a painful angry dirge)*

I wish to live in a land of cotton,
Old times there are never forgotten,
Look away, look away, look away, Dixieland.

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SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Charlayne Woodward
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AWARD HISTORY

2001 National Qualifier
2004 National Qualifier
2005 National Qualifier
2006 National Qualifier
2007 National Qualifier
2009 National Qualifier
2012 National Qualifier
2014 National Qualifier
2015 National Qualifier
2017 National Qualifier
2019 National Qualifier
CO State Qualifier
IL State Qualifier
NE State Qualifier